FREE GUIDE · @BUILDWITHABINASH

Buying land or a house? *Check these papers first.*

Every document you need in Tamil Nadu, for a plot, a flat or a house you build yourself, and how to check each one.

Most of us buy property once, maybe twice, in our whole life. The money is big, and the paperwork is where people get caught. I put this guide together so that when you sit with a seller, a builder or your engineer, you know which paper to ask for, what it proves and where you can check it yourself.

1. **Patta, EC and the parent documents tell you who owns it.** Check all three before you pay even a token advance.
2. **DTCP, CMDA and RERA tell you if it was laid out and built legally.** A plot that is far cheaper than the area rate usually has a reason.
3. **Building your own house has its own set of papers.** Building permit before the first brick, completion papers before you move in.

STAMP DUTY	REGISTRATION	HISTORY TO CHECK	RERA NEEDED ABOVE
7%	2%	30 yrs	500 m²

PART 1 · THE BASICS

Three pairs of words *people mix up*

Get these six clear first. Almost every property conversation in Tamil Nadu uses them, and most people use at least one of them wrongly.

DOCUMENT	WHAT IT TELLS YOU	WHO GIVES IT
Patta	Whose name the land is recorded under in government revenue records. Also the survey number, extent and land type.	Revenue Department (Taluk office, Tahsildar)
Chitta	The village-level record of the land's classification: nanjai (wet land) or punjai (dry land), extent and holder.	Village Administrative Officer (VAO)
Sale deed	The registered document that moves ownership from the seller to you. This is the legal proof that the sale happened.	Signed by both sides, registered at the Sub-Registrar office
Title deed	Any document that proves ownership. Once registered, your sale deed becomes your title deed. "Clear title" means every past deed in the chain is clean.	Not a separate certificate
DTCP / CMDA	Approval of a layout or a building by the planning authority. CMDA covers the Chennai Metropolitan Area, DTCP the rest of the state.	Town and Country Planning / CMDA
RERA	Registration of a real estate project. The builder has to disclose approvals, plans and the completion date, and follow the rules of the RERA Act.	Tamil Nadu Real Estate Regulatory Authority (TNRERA)

THIS TOOK ME A WHILE TO GET

Patta is a revenue record. The sale deed is the legal proof of ownership. You want both, and you want them to show the same name.

PATTA AND CHITTA TODAY

Tamil Nadu now issues Patta and Chitta together as one online extract, so when someone asks for "Patta Chitta" they mean that one printout from the e-Services portal. In towns and cities, land under the town survey has a TSLR (Town Survey Land Register) extract instead. Same job, urban version.

The revenue records, *and how to check them online*

These come from the Revenue Department, not the registration office. They tell you what the government's land records say about the plot.

1 The four records to pull

RECORD	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Patta (with Chitta)	Seller's name, survey number and sub-division, extent and land type. The name should match the seller's sale deed exactly.
A-Register (Adangal)	The village register for the survey number: classification, cultivation and past entries. Most useful for rural and agricultural land.
FMB sketch	Field Measurement Book sketch. Shows the shape, boundaries and measurements of the survey number. Walk the site and compare.
TSLR extract	The urban record for town survey land. Shows ward, block and town survey number instead of a village survey number.

2 How to check a Patta yourself

1. **Open eservices.tn.gov.in.** Pick the option to view Patta / Chitta / TSLR extract (rural or urban).
2. **Choose district, taluk and village.** For urban land, choose town, ward and block.
3. **Enter the survey number and sub-division** from the seller's papers. You get a digitally signed extract with a QR code. Download the FMB sketch from the same site.
4. **Use "Verify Patta"** on the same portal to confirm that a printout the seller gave you is genuine. Also check the poramboke option, which flags government land.

> THE ONE THING TO NOTICE
>
> The name on the Patta, the name on the seller's sale deed and the person signing your deed should be the same person. If they are not, stop and ask why.

A mismatch is not always fraud. The owner may have died and the heirs are selling, or the Patta was never updated. But each gap needs a document that explains it.

PART 3 · OWNERSHIP

Proving the seller *really owns it*

Revenue records can lag behind. The registered documents are what a court looks at, so this is where most of your checking time should go.

3 Ownership papers to ask for

DOCUMENT	WHY YOU NEED IT
Seller's sale deed	Shows how the seller got the property. Ask to see the original, not just a photocopy.
Parent (link) documents	Every earlier deed for at least 30 years: sale, settlement, gift, partition, will. Each owner should hand over to the next with no gap.
Encumbrance Certificate	Lists every registered transaction on the property for the years you search. Search 30 years.
Legal heir certificate, will	When the seller inherited it. Every legal heir has to sign the sale or release their share.
Power of attorney	If someone sells on behalf of the owner. It must be registered, still valid, give the power to sell, and the owner must be alive.
Loan closure papers	If the property was ever mortgaged: the bank's closure letter and proof the originals were returned.
Tax and EB receipts	Latest property tax and electricity bills. They show who has been paying and that nothing is due.

4 Reading an Encumbrance Certificate

You can search and download an EC on **tnreginet.gov.in** by survey number or document number. If the years you need aren't available online, apply at the Sub-Registrar office. The EC comes in one of two forms:

FORM 15

There were registered transactions in the period: sales, mortgages, partitions. Read every entry and match it with the parent documents.

FORM 16

Nil encumbrance. Nothing was registered on the property in the period you searched.

WHAT AN EC WON'T SHOW

Only registered transactions appear. An unregistered agreement, a pending court case or a family dispute won't be there. This is why I'd pay a property lawyer for a title opinion on the full set of documents. It costs far less than one bad purchase.

PART 4 · APPROVALS FOR PLOTS

Is the plot *legally a house site?*

Farmland can't simply be cut into plots and sold. For a plot to be a valid house site, the layout needs approval from the planning authority.

5 Who approves what

AUTHORITY	WHERE	WHAT TO ASK FOR
CMDA	Chennai Metropolitan Area	Planning permission letter and the approved layout or building plan, with its approval number.
DTCP	Rest of Tamil Nadu, including its local planning authorities in cities like Coimbatore and Madurai	Layout approval letter and the approved layout plan, with your plot number and size marked.
Local body	Corporation, municipality or panchayat	Building permit for construction, and property tax assessment once built.
TNRERA	Projects on more than 500 sq m of land with more than 8 units, all phases counted	RERA registration number, checked on rera.tn.gov.in against the brochure.

6 What to check on an approved layout

1. **Your plot is on the approved plan** with the same number, size and shape as in your sale deed.
2. **Roads and open space were handed over** to the local body, as the approval requires. Plots carved out of the park area are a common trap.
3. **The land use is residential** in the master plan, and the plot is not on a water body, poramboke land or a road-widening reservation.
4. **For plots in unapproved layouts,** ask for the regularisation order. Tamil Nadu's 2017 regularisation rules covered plots in unapproved layouts that were registered before 20 October 2016.

> WHAT FINALLY SETTLED IT FOR ME
>
> A plot with no approval and no regularisation is cheap today and expensive later. Bank loans, building permits and EB connections all get harder.

Buying a new flat? *The builder should show you these*

With a flat you buy two things: a share of the land and the apartment built on it. The papers follow the same split.

7 Before you pay the booking amount

DOCUMENT	WHAT TO CHECK
RERA registration	Project listed on rera.tn.gov.in with the same name, promoter and number as the brochure. Read the approved plan and completion date filed there.
Planning permission and building permit	From CMDA or DTCP and the local body. Count the floors and flats on the approved plan. Floors that aren't on it are a risk.
Land title	Parent documents, EC and Patta for the land. If a landowner gave the land to the builder under a joint development agreement (JDA), ask for the JDA and the power of attorney.
Bank NOC	Many builders take a project loan against the land. Your flat should be released from that mortgage before your deed is registered.

8 What you'll sign, in order

1. **Agreement for sale.** Under the RERA Act, a builder can't take more than 10% of the price as advance before a registered agreement for sale.
2. **UDS sale deed.** For a flat still being built, you usually buy an Undivided Share (UDS) of the land through a sale deed. Check the UDS area. That is your real share of the land. For a ready flat, one sale deed now covers both the land share and the flat.
3. **Construction agreement** (for a flat under construction). Specifications, payment stages tied to construction progress, the delivery date and the penalty for delay. It is registered too, so ask the builder for the full cost break-up early.
4. **Completion certificate, then possession.** Take possession after the completion certificate is issued. Ask for a possession letter and copies of the approved plans.

> GOOD TO KNOW ABOUT RERA
>
> A RERA number means the builder has disclosed the project and can be held to it. It doesn't confirm that the land title is clean or that the flat will be handed over on time. Check the title separately, as in Part 3.

Resale house or flat: *the extra papers*

Everything in Parts 2 and 3 still applies. A home someone has already lived in adds a few more papers on top.

9 Add these to your list

DOCUMENT	WHY
Approved plan and completion certificate of the building	Shows it was built as approved. Compare the floors and setbacks with what is actually standing.
The full chain for a flat	The first buyer's UDS sale deed and construction agreement, plus every resale deed after that.
Property tax receipts	In the seller's name with no arrears. You'll move the assessment to your name after buying.
EB and water bills	Latest receipts with no dues. These get transferred to you too.
Association NOC	For flats: no pending maintenance or corpus dues, and the association is fine with the transfer.
Home loan closure	If the seller still has a loan, the bank holds the originals. Agree in writing how the loan will be closed from your payment and when the originals come back.

CHECK ON SITE

- Measure the plot and match it with the FMB sketch and the deed
- Boundaries and neighbours as described in the deed
- No encroachment, no shared wall disputes
- Talk to two neighbours about the property's history

CHECK AT THE OFFICE

- EC for 30 years from tnreginet
- Guideline value for the street or survey number
- Tax and dues at the local body
- Lawyer's title opinion on the whole set

A SHORTCUT I USE NOW

If you're taking a home loan, the bank runs its own legal check. Ask for a copy of their legal and valuation report. It is a free second opinion.

PART 7 · BUILDING YOUR OWN HOUSE

Building a house: *papers before the first brick*

Owning the plot is step one. You need permission before construction starts, and a few more papers after it ends.

10 Before construction

1. **Plot papers in your name.** Registered sale deed, Patta transferred to you, and a fresh EC showing your purchase.
2. **Building plan** drawn and signed by a licensed architect or registered engineer, following the setbacks, height and floor area rules for your plot.
3. **Building permit.** Small homes can use the state's self-certification scheme on **onlineppa.tn.gov.in**: plot up to 2,500 sq ft, built-up area up to 3,500 sq ft, up to two homes, ground or ground plus one floor, up to 7 m tall (stilt plus two floors, up to 10 m, was added in September 2025). The plan is signed by a registered architect or engineer, you pay a flat fee per sq ft, e-sign a declaration and the permit is issued online. Larger buildings go through the regular approval of the local body, DTCP or CMDA.
4. **Contractor agreement.** Scope, specifications and brands, rates, stage-wise payments, timeline, and who fixes defects afterwards.
5. **Temporary EB connection** for construction, applied for with your permit.

11 After construction

6. **Completion certificate where needed.** Since 2024, residential buildings up to 14 m tall with up to 8 homes or up to 750 sq m (about 8,070 sq ft) of built-up area don't need one, including for the EB connection. Bigger buildings still do.
7. **Permanent EB, water and sewer connections** in your name.
8. **Property tax assessment** at the local body, so the new building is on record in your name.

> **SELF-CERTIFICATION IS STILL A RULEBOOK**
>
> The permit comes fast, but officials pick applications every month for site inspection, and a false declaration can be prosecuted. Build what the plan says. In August 2026 the state also announced that self-certification would extend to ground plus two and stilt plus three homes up to 5,000 sq ft. As of early November 2026 that had not been notified, so check the portal before you plan around it.

PART 8 · REGISTRATION DAY AND AFTER

What registration costs, *and what to do after*

Tamil Nadu rates. They are charged on the guideline value or the price in the deed, whichever is higher.

12 The costs

ITEM	RATE	ON A ₹50 LAKH PROPERTY
Stamp duty (sale deed)	7%	₹3,50,000
Registration fee	2%	₹1,00,000
Total to keep aside	9%	₹4,50,000
Women buyers, property up to ₹10 lakh	1% fee	₹10,000 saved on ₹10 lakh
Settlement deed to a family member	1% + 1%	capped at ₹40,000 + ₹10,000

The women's concession (from 1 April 2025) cuts the registration fee from 2% to 1% for houses, plots and farmland up to ₹10 lakh registered in a woman's name. Joint purchases with a man may not qualify, so confirm at the Sub-Registrar office. Check the guideline value for your street or survey number on tnreginet.gov.in.

13 On the day

Book a slot and pay the stamp duty and fee online on tnreginet. Seller and buyer both go to the Sub-Registrar office with ID, PAN, photos and two witnesses. If the price is ₹50 lakh or more, you as the buyer deduct 1% TDS and deposit it with the income tax department.

14 The week after

1. **Patta transfer.** If the whole extent moves with no subdivision, the Patta changes to your name automatically and you can download it from the e-Services portal. If the land has to be subdivided, it needs a survey, which revenue officials are meant to finish within 30 days.
2. **Property tax, EB and water** moved to your name at the local body and TNEB.
3. **Collect the original registered deed,** pull a fresh EC to confirm your sale shows up, and keep the originals somewhere safe with scanned copies.

PART 9 · YOUR CHECKLIST

Tick these off *before you pay*

Print this page and carry it. If a box stays empty, ask for that paper before money changes hands.

BUYING A PLOT

- ☐ Seller's original sale deed
- ☐ Parent documents, 30 years
- ☐ EC for 30 years
- ☐ Patta in seller's name
- ☐ FMB sketch matches site
- ☐ A-Register (rural land)
- ☐ DTCP / CMDA layout approval
- ☐ Approved layout plan with your plot
- ☐ Regularisation order (if any)
- ☐ Legal heir papers / PoA (if any)
- ☐ Latest tax receipts
- ☐ Lawyer's title opinion

BUYING A FLAT

- ☐ RERA number checked online
- ☐ Planning permission
- ☐ Building permit and approved plan
- ☐ Land title and EC
- ☐ JDA and PoA (if any)
- ☐ Bank NOC on project loan
- ☐ Registered agreement for sale
- ☐ UDS sale deed
- ☐ Construction agreement
- ☐ Completion certificate
- ☐ Possession letter
- ☐ Association NOC (resale)

BUILDING A HOUSE

- ☐ Sale deed in your name
- ☐ Patta transferred to you
- ☐ Fresh EC
- ☐ Approved or regularised plot
- ☐ Plan by licensed architect / engineer
- ☐ Building permit
- ☐ Contractor agreement
- ☐ Temporary EB connection
- ☐ Completion certificate (if needed)
- ☐ Permanent EB and water
- ☐ Property tax assessment
- ☐ All bills and receipts filed

SLOW DOWN IF YOU SEE ANY OF THESE

- Seller pushes you to pay an advance today
- Only photocopies, never the originals
- Patta in a name that isn't the seller's, with no explanation
- Sale through a power of attorney you can't verify
- Price far below the guideline value of the area
- "Approval is coming" for the layout or building
- More floors standing than the approved plan shows
- Gaps in the 30-year chain of documents

WORDS YOU'LL HEAR

The glossary, *in plain words*

I didn't know half of these the first time someone said them across a table. Here they are, each in one line.

Patta
REVENUE RECORD OF RIGHTS

Government record of who holds the land, with survey number and extent.

"Indha land yaar perla irukku-nu sollum."

Chitta
VILLAGE LAND REGISTER

Land type (nanjai or punjai) and extent at the village level. Now part of the Patta extract.

"Enna vagaiyaana land-nu sollum."

A-Register
ADANGAL

Village register for each survey number: classification, cultivation and history.

"Village-la land oda full details."

FMB sketch
FIELD MEASUREMENT BOOK

Map of the survey number with its boundaries and measurements.

"Land oda shape-um alavum."

TSLR
TOWN SURVEY LAND REGISTER

The urban version of the Patta record, by ward, block and town survey number.

"City land-kku Patta maadhiri."

EC
ENCUMBRANCE CERTIFICATE

List of every registered transaction on a property for the years you search.

"Indha property mela enna nadandhuchu-nu kaatum."

Sale deed
REGISTERED TRANSFER DOCUMENT

The deed that moves ownership from seller to buyer once registered.

"Vaangina proof idhu dhaan."

Parent documents
LINK DOCUMENTS

All earlier deeds that show how the property passed from owner to owner.

"Munnadi owners-oda chain."

Guideline value
GOVERNMENT MINIMUM VALUE

The rate the state fixes per sq ft or acre. Stamp duty is charged on this or the deed price, whichever is higher.

"Govt fix panna minimum rate."

UDS
UNDIVIDED SHARE OF LAND

Your share of the land under an apartment building, bought through a sale deed.

"Flat-kku keela unga land share."

DTCP / CMDA
PLANNING AUTHORITIES

Approve layouts and buildings. CMDA for Chennai metro, DTCP for the rest of TN.

"Layout-kku approval kudukkuradhu."

RERA
REAL ESTATE REGULATORY AUTHORITY

Registers projects above 500 sq m with more than 8 units and holds builders to what they disclosed.

"Builder rules follow panraangalaa-nu paakkum."

Completion certificate
CC

Confirms the building was finished as per the approved plan.

"Plan padi katti mudichaachu-nu proof."

Poramboke
GOVERNMENT LAND

Land set aside for public use, like water bodies or roads. It can't be sold privately.

"Govt land, yaarum vikka mudiyaadhu."

Power of attorney
POA

A registered document that lets one person act for the owner, including selling if it says so.

"Owner badhila innoruthar sign pannuvaanga."

SOURCES AND DISCLAIMER

Where the *rules and numbers* came from

Checked in November 2026. Property rules and portals in Tamil Nadu change often, so confirm the current position before you act.

1. Patta, Chitta, A-Register, FMB, TSLR and the Verify Patta option: Tamil Nadu e-Services land records portal (eservices.tn.gov.in), as described by Verified.RealEstate, July 2025.
2. EC search and download, Form 15 and Form 16: tnreginet.gov.in; Housing.com, April 2025; Square Yards, June 2026.
3. Stamp duty 7% and registration fee 2% on sale and gift deeds, the 2% applying from 1 April 2023 under G.O. (Ms) No. 34: Government of Tamil Nadu stamp duty and registration fee schedule, TN Single Window Portal (last updated 22 January 2025); Asianet Newsable, April 2025. Some 2025 and 2026 blogs still quote the old 4% fee.
4. Women's registration fee concession, one percentage point off (2% to 1%) for property up to ₹10 lakh registered in a woman's name, effective 1 April 2025: TN Budget 2025-26 (14 March 2025); DT Next, 31 March 2025; Asianet Newsable, 1 April 2025.
5. Settlement, partition and release among family members, 1% stamp duty (max ₹40,000) and 1% registration fee (max ₹10,000) from 10 July 2023 under G.O. (Ms) No. 69: TN stamp duty and registration fee schedule (January 2025); DT Next and Housing.com, July 2023.
6. Self-certification building permit: G.O. (Ms) No. 133, 18 July 2024, launched 22 July 2024 on onlineppa.tn.gov.in; stilt plus two (up to 10 m) live from 3 September 2025 under G.O. (Ms) No. 118; extension to G+2 and stilt+3 up to 5,000 sq ft announced 28 August 2026, not notified as of 5 November 2026 (MyPropertyPoint, November 2026; BuildWatch News, September 2025; Verified.RealEstate).
7. Completion certificate not needed for residential buildings up to 14 m with up to 8 dwelling units or 750 sq m, under the 2024 amendments to the TN Combined Development and Building Rules, 2019: DT Next, 11 March 2024, 30 June 2024 and 1 March 2026.
8. RERA registration: Section 3(2)(a) of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 exempts projects on 500 sq m or less, or with 8 units or fewer. TNRERA registration as a condition for the completion certificate: DT Next, 17 December 2018. Tribunal ruling that subdividing survey numbers doesn't avoid registration: DT Next, September 2022.
9. Advance capped at 10% before a registered agreement for sale: Section 13, Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016.
10. Automatic Patta transfer when there is no subdivision, 30-day survey for subdivision cases, and the June 2026 order extending it to joint family and PoA deeds: DT Next, 4 July 2026; Verified.RealEstate.
11. Regularisation of plots in unapproved layouts registered before 20 October 2016: Tamil Nadu regularisation rules, 2017.
12. Worked example: ₹50,00,000 × 7% = ₹3,50,000; × 2% = ₹1,00,000; total ₹4,50,000. Women's saving: ₹10,00,000 × 1% = ₹10,000.

DISCLAIMER

This guide is for education only. It is not legal, tax or investment advice, and it does not recommend any specific builder, layout, lender or service. I am not a lawyer or a SEBI-registered investment adviser. Rates, thresholds and online services are as of November 2026 and can change. Get a property lawyer's title opinion, and check with the Sub-Registrar office, your local planning authority and TNRERA before you pay or sign anything.

Which paper confused you the most? *Tell me on Instagram.*

Free to share. Made by Abinash at **@buildwithabinash**. Send this to a friend who is about to pay an advance on a plot or a flat.